

Hot Flashes and How to Manage Them

Hot flashes are one of the most common and disruptive symptoms of menopause. They involve a sudden feeling of intense heat that spreads through the body—often with flushing, dizziness, sweating, or, in some cases, chills afterward. Episodes typically last a few minutes but can feel much longer.

About 80% of women going through menopause experience hot flashes. They can begin as early as age 40 and may continue for 7–10 years. Hot flashes are also common in women who:

- Are perimenopausal or menopausal
- Experience early or premature menopause
- Have had their ovaries surgically removed
- Receive treatments that affect hormone levels

When hot flashes occur at night, they are known as night sweats, which can disrupt sleep and lead to fatigue, reduced productivity, and mood or relationship changes.

What Causes Hot Flashes?

Declining estrogen levels during menopause is the primary cause. However, several factors can worsen symptoms, including:

- Anxiety or mood changes
- Spicy foods
- Alcohol
- Caffeine

Research shows that Black women may be up to 50% more likely to experience hot flashes. Obesity is also a known risk factor.

Managing Hot Flashes

Hot flashes can significantly impact quality of life, but several treatment options are available. Because responses to treatment vary, management should be individualized.

Lifestyle Strategies

- Dress in light, removable layers
- Use a portable fan
- Maintain a healthy weight
- Practice mindfulness or meditation
- Avoid known dietary and emotional triggers

Medical Options

Hormone replacement therapy (HRT) is often effective but is not recommended for individuals with certain cancers, heart disease, or blood clotting disorders.

For those who cannot take hormones, non-hormonal treatments may help. A healthcare provider can determine the best approach based on medical history and symptoms.

When to Seek Help

Women do not need to suffer in silence. If hot flashes affect sleep, energy, or daily life, medical support is available. A healthcare provider can evaluate symptoms and recommend personalized treatment options.

For questions or more information, please contact info@yarrowcare.com.